



Over fishing

Satellite data indicates that fishermen are harvesting more than half of the world's oceans. <http://digit.in/TooFish>



Tinder vulnerability

Vulnerabilities in Tinder and in Facebook's Account Kit tool allow takeover of a Tinder account using only the victim's phone number. <http://digit.in/TinHack>

Do it like Dolittle

Is talking to your pets even possible?

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ven though you might not be an animal person (and by that we mean someone who loves animals), if

you watch almost any well-made documentary on the evolution of human civilisation over its history, the important role that our pets and domesticated fauna have played will be quite evident. From agriculture to poultry, and even to cuddling with us on a bad day (or not, if you have a cat), animals have been there for us. Which explains our need to try and understand what they've been saying all these years.

As any pet owner would tell you, there is a particular way in which most animals communicate. Dogs have evolved over the years to be particularly suited as pets, even learning complex actions through training and for rewards. But that still doesn't mean that a dog can do much beyond wagging its tail, and barking in a particular way. There still remains a gap in most animal-human communication that, if filled, would at the very least help us understand greatly what an animal goes through when we treat them the way we do. So, in today's era of artificial intelligence and flying cars, have we really been able to come up with technology that can enable all of us to become Dr. Dolittles for our furry and winged friends?

DO THEY EVEN TALK?

To understand what an animal is saying, we first need to make sure that they are actually saying something. For ages, we've lived with dogs, parrots, horses and more, and there have been instances where we've seen them make intelligible sounds, actions and even pronounce words. We're talking

to their fellow animals. But language is an entirely different ball game.

To put it simply, possessing a language is dependent on certain abilities – the ability to question (ask 'why?') and the ability to negate (say 'no'), neither of which have been displayed by animals or birds. Even famous examples of animals imitating human



Alex is the best known example of a non-human being capable of complex human speech

about talking parrots here. Even killer whales, orcas and elephants can seemingly pull this off. But almost all of it has been trained behavior in return for rewards and they haven't actually been trying to communicate at all.

Animals have been known to exhibit other complex behavior. Mammals of all kinds have been shown to have what we, as humans, define as culture. They employ deception, recognise themselves in mirrors, and are even capable of showing emotions

words or creating human-like vowel-consonant combined sounds have been due to a behavior called vocal imitation. Except for a few exceptions like Alex the African grey parrot who learnt more than a 1000 words and would perform complex interactions like wishing his trainer goodnight when she left and indicating when he wants to sit near a window using a verbal phrase.

Checkout how Google translate for animals works at <http://digit.in/GT4Animals>